

About being independent

I REMEMBER WHEN I WAS A WEE BOY, AND CONSTANTLY PESTERED MY DAD TO BUY ME A GAMEBOY

— well, not exactly the original Gameboy, but its cheaper, Chinese knock-off (as I later found out). It was clearly more expensive than any other toy my parents had bought for me until then. The most common retort to my repeated requests for a Gameboy was, “Buy one with your own money when you get a job and start earning a living.” Not to say my parents didn’t indulge most of my desires and demands (they’re nothing but generous and accommodating), they were just against instant gratification of any kind, especially those accompanied by unruly tantrums. It really made me fantasize about growing up and being my own man. I couldn’t wait to become independent — I’d get to watch cartoons all day and night, play on my Gameboy whenever I wanted, and never have to do homework ever again! Oh my childish whims and fancies!

Later on in my teen years, when my parents vetoed my request to purchase the original iMac (circa 1998) because it was the coolest computer I had ever seen, I had to settle instead for an assembled PC which wasn’t as attractive (but was more affordable, as you can imagine). Of course, I couldn’t just have a PC without a dial-up internet connection (in the pursuit of academic excellence), and upgrades to the PC’s graphics and peripherals were demanded periodically. At that point, I absolutely couldn’t wait to get independent to quench my thirst for all things digital, with or without my parents’ consent.

So this whole idea of being independent one day (to do my own bidding) stems from a strong childhood desire for gadgets, games and gizmos. When I moved out of the home to pursue my first job, I didn’t waste any time getting my first laptop, phone, several online subscriptions and other digital distractions. Independence was finally here and I couldn’t have enough of it!

Of course, as readers and followers of Digit, I would imagine most of you have had similar life experiences while growing up. Despite our brain agreeing with our parents’ logic about spending money wisely, I’d imagine that nothing gave our hearts more joy than to indulge in our digital desires — whether it’s buying a slightly cooler phone, or a faster graphics card, or an expensive

audio system for superior sound — and savour every moment. Memories that transcend from mere digital independence to instances of absolute digital nirvana, when you look back and take stock of your personal highlights.

While my yearning for the best digital indulgence I can experience and own has tempered with age, it’s an itch far easily scratched thanks to the absolute privilege of working here at Digit. We get to touch, use and play with some of the absolute best technology products money can buy, every single week. Phones, laptops, TVs, audio products, PC peripherals, and more — we experience them all. Nevertheless, what remains insatiable is the desire for faster Internet connection speed — especially because there’s a huge gulf between the broadband speed I experience at work versus my broadband connection speed at home. Independence from pesky internet speed limits still remains an unfulfilled personal dream of mine, and hopefully it’s just a matter of time before I sign up for a FTTH provider — as soon as they start services in my residential area.

Independence from online corporations who collect and mine our data is another aspect of the Internet’s evolution that I’m looking forward to observing and experiencing. People like Sir Tim Berners-Lee and those running blockchain-based Web3 services will try to promote the adoption of a decentralised world wide web in the coming years, to restore power back into each and every netizen’s hands. Independence will truly take on a whole new meaning online, if this perennial pipe dream is to become a mainstream reality.

Well, this was my two cents on digital independence — its past, present and future. What does digital independence mean to you? Write to me and tell me how you see it unfolding... 



“So this whole idea of being independent one day (to do my own bidding) stems from a strong childhood desire for gadgets, games and gizmos.”



Let me know your thoughts on this column at: jayesh.shinde@digit.in | @jshinde